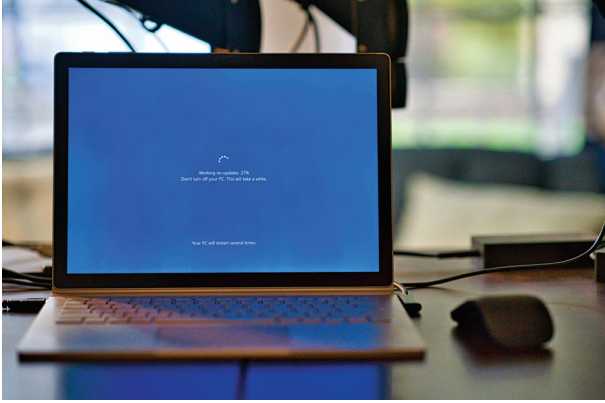


any available Windows patches (this may include the latest feature update, e.g. Windows 11 24H2 (2024 update), which you should allow to install for the newest features and security). Reboot when prompted. Repeat the check until it says your system is up-to-date. This ensures you have the latest security patches and improvements.



4. **Upgrade system drivers:** After Windows updates, verify that all hardware drivers are correctly installed. Open Device Manager (Press Win + X and choose Device Manager) and look for any device with a yellow exclamation mark or “unknown device” label. If you see any, you may need to install drivers from the laptop manufacturer’s support site. Otherwise, for a thorough check, use Windows Update’s optional drivers feature: go to Settings > Windows Update > Advanced options > Optional updates. Under “Driver updates,” see if any are listed for your components (graphics, Wi-Fi, etc.) and install them. If no driver updates show up in that list, Windows likely already obtained the necessary drivers. For dedicated graphics (e.g. NVIDIA/AMD), you might also download the latest driver from the GPU maker’s website for best performance once you’re online. Keeping drivers updated can improve stability and performance for new hardware.
5. **Enable security features (Firewall, Antivirus, SmartScreen):** Windows 11 comes with Microsoft Defender Antivirus and Firewall active by default. After updates, open Windows Security (search for it in Start) to verify everything is green. Check Virus & threat protection – it should say “no action needed.” Click “Check for updates” in the Virus protection section to ensure Defender’s antivirus definitions are current. Also ensure Firewall & network protection is on (it is on by default). These built-in protections are quite good for most users. If you prefer a third-party antivirus, you can install it now (just ensure only one AV is active at a time to avoid conflicts).
6. **Set up Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA):** Strengthen the security of your accounts by enabling two-factor or multi-factor authentication for your Microsoft account and other important logins (email, cloud storage, banking, etc.). MFA

adds an extra verification (like a code on your phone or a fingerprint) on top of your password, so even if someone guesses your password they can’t sign in. This dramatically improves security – according to Microsoft and cyber agencies, turning on MFA can prevent 99% of automated hacking attempts on your accounts. On your Microsoft account, enable two-step verification under account security settings. For other services, check their security or account settings for two-factor options and follow their setup process (usually linking your phone or an authenticator app). This step only takes a few minutes per account but greatly reduces the risk of account breaches.

7. **Enable device encryption (BitLocker):** Modern Windows laptops often have Device Encryption automatically enabled if you signed in with a Microsoft account during setup. Let’s double-check: Go to Settings > Privacy & Security > Device Encryption (or search for “Device encryption”). If the toggle is On, your SSD is already encrypted, which protects your data if the laptop is lost or stolen. If it’s Off (and your system meets requirements like having a TPM), toggle it On to encrypt your drive. For Windows 11 Home, this “Device Encryption” is a simplified BitLocker – it will automatically encrypt and back up your recovery key to your Microsoft account. On Windows 11 Pro, you can alternatively use full BitLocker (found under Control Panel > BitLocker Drive Encryption) for more options. Either way, encryption ensures no one can access your files just by removing your drive, giving you peace of mind. (If Device Encryption isn’t available due to hardware limits, you can skip this step.) Once enabled, let the encryption process finish in the background (you can keep using the PC).
8. **Configure privacy settings:** Take a tour through Windows 11’s privacy toggles to disable any data collection or annoying “features” you don’t want. Open Settings > Privacy & Security. Under General, you’ll find switches for things like “Let apps show me personalized ads by using my advertising ID” – toggle these off to opt out of targeted ads and some app tracking. Also consider turning off “Tailored experiences” under Diagnostics & feedback, so Microsoft doesn’t use your diagnostic data to personalize suggestions. While you cannot turn off basic diagnostic telemetry entirely, you can make sure “Send optional diagnostic data” is off to limit what’s sent. Next, review permissions for Location, Camera, Microphone, etc. (in Privacy & Security section) – if you don’t want certain apps to have access, revoke it. For example, if you never use voice dictation, you can disable Online speech recognition. In Notifications settings (under System), you might also turn off tips and welcome experiences that tend to spam you. These adjustments will protect your privacy and cut down on distractions from Windows.
9. **Set up Windows Hello and Account protection:** If your laptop has a fingerprint reader or IR facial camera, set up